

sourcing standards to keep pace with our demand. Everything from the clothes you wear<sup>8</sup> to the car you drive<sup>9</sup> has been linked to forced labor at some point in the manufacturing process.

Our overconsumption gives permission to businesses to engage in these unethical business practices. Our willful silence as we continue to “buy now” tells them we want them to keep doing what they’re doing.

Values-based spending is about so much more than getting what you love. It’s also your responsibility to the world around you. It’s your civic duty to buy what you love and not consume beyond it. Your spending is how you advocate for yourself, your friends, family, community, and people you will never meet who may not currently have the resources to advocate for themselves. Because if we don’t, the problem will get worse.

And here’s the thing: Our responsibility to do better for others can be a heavy burden. We all know we should be concerned about helping the environment, but there are so many things going “wrong” and so many “right” things to do that we may get overwhelmed. It’s the same with responsible spending. There’s no way to know how every business is sourcing their goods, manufacturing their products, or treating their workers. It’s impossible, and it leads to giving up on doing anything. But every small effort in the right direction makes an impact. A big impact.

We can tackle large problems by taking small steps. One example is with our cell phones. According to the International Energy Agency, manufacturing in China emitted 11.9 billion tons of carbon dioxide<sup>10</sup> emissions in 2021, accounting for 33 percent of the global total emissions. In 2022, over 40 percent of US goods<sup>11</sup> were imported from China, with electronics at the top<sup>12</sup> of the list. Most people upgrade their phones every two to three years. One small step anyone can take is keeping your current phone for one more year than you may have planned on. If everyone did it, we could cut new production by 1.39 billion phones<sup>13</sup> in less than five years! It probably won’t happen, but we can dream, right?

Where the big impact is really possible is through these small changes. On an individual level, if you kept your phone for three years instead of two, you’d personally buy four to five fewer phones over thirty years, which doesn’t seem like a huge impact, but it could save you at least \$4,000. But you also give permission to others to keep their phone for an extra year. The more normal it becomes to wait that additional year, the more people who’ll do it, including some of the 12 percent of Americans